

The Boston Globe

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TUESDAY, DECEMBER 24, 2024

City, soccer team in White Stadium deal

10 years
length of the initial lease,
with two 10-year
extensions.

\$200,000
the prorated rent in the
first season.

\$400,000
what the team will pay in
year two, with annual
increases of at least 3
percent.

Parties to share in \$182 million renovation of decaying BPS venue, but lawsuit remains

By Michael Silverman
GLOBE STAFF

Boston's new professional women's soccer team signed a lease Monday to become a tenant of the City of Boston at White Stadium, where the two parties will share in a slated \$182-million-plus renovation of the crumbling 75-year-old Franklin Park venue.

Demolition and construction are expected to begin next month, which leaves a tight timeline for BOS Nation

FC and the city to complete their work by the start of the National Women's Soccer League's season in March 2026.

In a Zoom call, Mayor Michelle Wu, along with other supporters of the project, heralded "the largest investment into [Boston Public Schools] athletics and White Stadium since it opened in 1949."

She said the stadium will become "the anchor for citywide youth sports, access, revitalize community program-

ming, deliver needed ongoing investments into our beloved historic Franklin Park, all while creating a home for the City of Champions' newest professional team."

Along with its rapidly rising cost estimates, the ambitious public-private project has faced considerable public opposition, including an ongoing lawsuit that could delay progress on the 11,000-seat stadium, which needs to be ready within 15 months.

Controlling owner Jennifer Epstein said that construction will proceed "at an accelerated timeline" but that con-

WHITE STADIUM, Page A10

President commutes 37 death sentences

Move undercuts Trump's vow to restart executions; Tsarnaev's case unchanged

By Aishvarya Kavi
NEW YORK TIMES

WASHINGTON — President Biden on Monday commuted the sentences of nearly all prisoners on federal death row, sparing the lives of 37 men just a month before Donald Trump will return to the Oval Office with a promise to restart federal executions.

Those affected by Biden's action, all of whom were convicted of murder, will serve life imprisonment without the possibility of parole instead of facing execution. Only three men, who each carried out notorious mass killings, will remain on federal death row. Among the three is Dzhokhar Tsarnaev, 31, who with his brother set off the bombs at the Boston Marathon finish line in 2013, killing three spectators and injuring about 260 others.

The president campaigned in 2020 on ending the federal death penalty. Although proposed legislation to that effect failed to advance in Congress during his administration, Biden directed the Justice Department to issue a moratorium on federal executions. Thirteen prisoners on federal death row were put to death during Trump's first term.

"I am more convinced than ever that we must stop the use of the death penalty at the federal level," Biden said in a statement Monday. "In good

BIDEN, Page A6

Report accuses Gaetz of sex, drug crimes

House panel links former lawmaker to underage girl

By Luke Broadwater, Maggie Haberman, and Robert Draper
NEW YORK TIMES

WASHINGTON — The House Ethics Committee said Monday its lengthy investigation had found that former representative Matt Gaetz of Florida, President-elect Donald Trump's initial choice for attorney general, had regularly paid women for sex, had sex with an underage girl, and used illegal drugs.

The report was released weeks after the Republican withdrew from consideration to be the nation's chief law enforcement officer and resigned from Congress, and after years in which he had spawned enemies on both sides of the aisle with his bellicose political style.

Gaetz has denied any wrongdoing. The panel found that from at least 2017 to 2020, Gaetz "regularly paid women for engaging in sexual activity with him." The report said that in 2017, Gaetz had "engaged in sexual activity with a 17-year-old girl," who was paid.

From 2017 to 2019, the report said, Gaetz used or possessed illegal drugs, including cocaine and

GAETZ, Page A7



By Carlos Muñoz
GLOBE STAFF

STONINGTON, Conn. — Lisa Konicki recognized the nervous look. She pulled out her phone and got ready to take pictures.

In the center of the Stonington Lobster Trap Tree, surrounded by steel and fishing buoys and lights, a young man turned to his partner and knelt in the grass. A kaleidoscope of light cast them in a warm Christmas glow. For the 28th time since the tree was created in 2021, a lover popped the question: Will you marry me?

"We have a perfect score," said Konicki, the president of Ocean Community Chamber of Commerce. So far, they've all said yes.

Visiting the Lobster Trap Tree in Stonington Borough has become an annual winter tradition for thousands of people in New



PHOTOS BY BARRY CHIN/GLOBE STAFF

Parked cars reflected the Stonington Lobster Trap Tree's lights. Above, the 35-foot-tall pyramid of 460 traps is adorned with hundreds of painted fishing buoys.

England and beyond. The 35-foot-tall pyramid of 460 shiny lobster traps, draped in netting and lights and decorated with hundreds of painted fishing buoys, is a nod to the legacy of

local fishermen in the home of Connecticut's last commercial fishing fleet.

Konicki, who founded the Stonington installation, was inspired by one she saw years ago

while walking with family and friends in Gloucester.

"I was enamored with it; I thought it was beautiful," she said. "It was just sort of quintessential New England, and I admired all the buoys created by children. It was really a tribute to all the lobstermen in that community and fishing village in general, I thought, 'Wow, I'm from Stonington, Connecticut. We have the last commercial fishing village in the state. We should have something like this in our community and I'm going to do it.'"

The borough's Lobster Trap Tree is a showcase, decorated with the work of artists from Rhode Island and Connecticut.

"We're really standing in front of an outdoor art museum," Konicki said.

During the day, visitors can admire the detailed landscapes, portraits of people and pets,

CHRISTMAS TREE, Page A10

State leaders set to get hefty pay raises

Boost nearly 10%; biennial process tied to wage levels

By Matt Stout
GLOBE STAFF

The salaries of Massachusetts' top elected officials, including Governor Maura Healey, are due to swell by nearly 10 percent in the new year, and the pay of the Legislature's top leaders could jump by at least \$12,000, state officials said Monday.

Under an analysis released by state Treasurer Deborah Goldberg's office, all six statewide constitutional officers' salaries would rise by roughly \$19,000 or more beginning Jan. 1, meaning that the pay of each would top \$200,000 for the first time.

The change is part of a complicated biennial process, under which two separate adjustments — one guaranteed by the Massachusetts Constitution, the other baked into a 2017 law — tie the pay of the most powerful leaders to changes in the state's wage levels. The amount of each adjustment is determined by separate offices but it could also be based on different sets of data.

Healey's annual salary is set to rise to \$243,493, while her total compensation will reach \$308,493 when including an annual housing stipend the governor receives. Goldberg, a third-term Democrat, will receive the biggest one-time bump, a \$22,900 increase, that will push her salary to \$261,694 annually, the highest of any of Massachusetts

PAY RAISES, Page A10



\$308,493

Governor Maura Healey's total compensation includes a sizable housing stipend.



\$215,718

Speaker Ron Mariano's total compensation could increase, depending on an upcoming determination from the governor's office.



\$261,694

Treasurer Deborah Goldberg's salary would increase by the greatest amount, \$22,900.



White on cue

Christmas Eve: Snow early. High 32-37, low 21-26.

Christmas: Sun and clouds. High 32-37, low 24-29.

Sunrise: 7:11. Sunset: 4:16.

Weather and comics, **D5-6.**

Obituaries, **C10.**

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GETTY IMAGES FILE

The Red Sox signed starting pitcher Walker Buehler, a two-time All-Star with the Los Angeles Dodgers who has struggled through consecutive injury-filled seasons but who closed out the 2024 postseason with 10 scoreless innings, including the final out of the World Series (above) against the Yankees. **C1.**

Boston Mayor Michelle Wu, in a wide-ranging interview, gave a preview of her pitch to voters as she prepares to launch her bid for a second term. **B1.**



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